publicly remember the traumatic watershed of his career. Rather, it was a related personal experience in the slipstream of the Kalinga war that he shared, one which he hoped would inspire his people. So, I shall go back a little in time to Ashoka's first articulation of his metamorphosis, and through that remembrance explore how he sought to galvanize others along the same path.

The reception of any message, and most certainly a royal one, has a great deal to do with circumstances around its articulation. How was Ashoka's voice likely to have been understood by those who heard and read his words? As there are no references or reactions to Ashoka's edicts in any class of India's ancient literature of the first millennium BCE, our reconstruction has to be rooted in historical conjecture. Much of the Brahmanical literature of the late centuries BCE deals with subjects like codes of conduct, paraphernalia pertaining to rituals, norms of social behaviour, and the law. As such, events like the composition of kingly communiqués and citizens' reactions to them were never going to find mention. Nor were the Buddhist texts of the time in any way primarily concerned with kings who patronized Buddhism. They were preoccupied with the Buddha's discourses, his previous births, and the do's and dont's for monks and nuns. No account by any ambassador from a neighbouring kingdom of that era has turned up. If an *Indica* had been written around Ashoka's reign, containing information of the kind Megasthenes recorded about Chandragupta, public reactions to the emperor's messages may well have featured.

All the same, some glimpses can be arrived at by juxtaposing the message with the cultural landscape—by looking at the various places across his empire where the words were inscribed, at the cultural patterns in those places as captured in the material evidence that has survived, and at what the emperor's sudden visibility in that world may have entailed. Exploring what has appeared in the archaeological record should at the very